

The UK's favourite type of humour

英国人钟爱的幽默形式

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配套音频与原文: <https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish/chinese/features/take-away-english/ep-260928>

在英国，“laughing at oneself（自嘲）”被许多人视为英国文化中极具代表性的一种幽默形式。当人们陷入困境时，适度的自嘲不仅可以拉近彼此之间的距离，还能缓解面对压力时的焦虑和紧张情绪。不过，对于那些难以接受自己成为玩笑对象的人来说，这种幽默风格并不容易掌握。什么情况下自嘲能展现幽默感？又在什么情况下可能适得其反，带来更多问题呢？本文将简要介绍自嘲这一独特的幽默形式。

词汇: humour 幽默

1 Over two thirds of Brits agree that being able to laugh at yourself, or what we call 'self-deprecating humour', is a defining part of British culture, according to a recent survey by the charity Comic Relief. British comedian Sir Lenny Henry says it's not about putting yourself down, it's about bringing people together. After years of doing stand-up comedy, Lenny says that laughing at yourself is "one of the quickest ways to feel connected to a room full of strangers". But when is it good, and when is it bad, to make fun of yourself? Can it be taken too far?

2 When a person points out their own flaws in a light-hearted way, it can make them seem more human and make others feel comfortable. A 2025 study called 'When Laughter Hurts and Helps' linked the joy of being laughed at with higher social connectedness, in other words, a greater sense of belonging to a group. Conversely, the trait 'gelotophobia', or someone who fears being laughed at, has been linked to greater friendship avoidance and lower life satisfaction. Even leaders might benefit from self-deprecating humour. Lecturer at Stanford Graduate School of Business Naomi Bagdonas says that for today's leaders, 'Humour is an elixir for trust and an antidote to arrogance'.

3 Making light of negative situations can also be a coping mechanism. Imagine you're working on a group project, and something goes wrong. While everyone is panicking and trying to find someone to blame, you say sarcastically, "Well, this is going well!" This gives people permission to laugh a bit, and they might feel more positively about the situation. The challenge doesn't vanish, but at least people feel less tense and could feel more able to deal with the situation. A 2024 study published in Europe's Journal of Psychology found that maintaining a humorous perspective when things go wrong can lead to greater resilience.

4 Of course, there's always a balance. While self-deprecating humour can bring people closer and make bad situations less overwhelming, it's important that it doesn't come from a place of bitterness and self-hatred. It's best to make jokes about yourself only once you've made peace with the flaw or mistake you're making fun of.

测验与练习

一、为本文选择总结句。

a. Laughing at oneself is seen as overall positive. b. Laughing at oneself is seen as overall negative. c. Laughing at oneself is seen as overall neutral.

二、根据文章内容选出正确的选项。

1. The majority of Brits think laughing at yourself is a key part of British culture, according to a survey.

a. True b. False c. Not given

2. The fear of being laughed at has negative consequences. a. True b. False c. Not given

3. Leaders making fun of themselves always leads to good outcomes. a. True b. False c. Not given

4. According to the article, making light of a bad situation... a. removes the challenges. b. makes people feel better. c. makes people feel tense.

5. Self-deprecation is always good. a. True b. False c. Not given

三、用下列单词完成对本文的总结。

In the UK, 1) _____ is popular. The point is to 2) _____ of yourself in a 3) _____ way. Research says this type of humour can lead to higher 4) _____, but it's important not to 5) _____. First, make sure you have made peace with your flaws to avoid making others feel awkward.

make fun make peace put yourself down social connectedness bitterness self-deprecating humour light-hearted

(答案见词汇表后)

词汇表

self-deprecating humour

自嘲式幽默 comedian 喜剧演员 put oneself down 贬低自己, 看轻自己, 否定自己 stand-up comedy 单口喜剧 make fun of someone/something 取笑某人或某事 light-hearted 轻松诙谐的, 轻松幽默的 social connectedness 社会联结感, 与他人的联结感 elixir 万能药, 灵丹妙药 antidote 解药, 良方 make light of something 对某事轻描淡写, 有意淡化某事的严重性 coping mechanism 应对机制 sarcastically 讽刺地, 挖苦地 humorous 幽默的 resilience 复原力 overwhelming 令人难以招架的, 压得人喘不过气的 bitterness 怨恨, 怨愤 make peace with something/oneself 坦然接受, 与...和解, 释怀

答案

一、为本文选择总结句。

1. a. Laughing at oneself is seen as overall positive.

二、根据文章内容选出正确的选项。

1. a. True . Over two thirds of Brits agree that being able to laugh at yourself, or what we call 'self-deprecating humour', is a defining part of British culture , according to a recent survey by the charity Comic Relief.
2. a. True. Conversely, the trait 'gelotophobia' , or someone who fears being laughed at, has been linked to greater friendship avoidance and lower life satisfaction .
3. c. Not given . Naomi Bagdonas says that for today's leaders, 'Humour is an elixir for trust and an antidote to arrogance', but such a strong claim is not made.
4. b. The challenge doesn't vanish, but at least people feel less tense and could feel more able to deal with the situation .
5. b. False. While self-deprecating humour can bring people closer and make bad situations less overwhelming, it's important that it doesn't come from a place of bitterness and self-hatred .

三、用下列单词完成对本文的总结。

In the UK, self-deprecating humour is popular. The point is to make fun of yourself in a light-hearted way. Research says this type of humour can lead to higher social connectedness , but it's important not to put yourself down .

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